

Animals

Number of known species 1,367,555

Habitat Land and water

Size range Less than 0.04 in (1 mm) to about 110 ft (33 m)

Animals cannot make foods such as sugar from raw chemicals, as plants do, so they have to find it ready-made. They survive by eating other living things, or things that were once alive. Some aquatic animals live out their adult lives rooted to one spot, and rely on the water to bring food within reach. But most animals—including all the ones that live on land—have various means of moving around so they can search for food. These include fins, legs, and wings, although many animals have other ways of moving, such as gliding on trails of slime like slugs, stretching and contracting their

soft bodies like worms, or wriggling like snakes. Animals include a huge variety of creatures, from microscopic worms to giant whales. Many aquatic animals, such as corals and sea anemones, look like plants because of the flowerlike shapes of their bodies. But most animals have distinct heads and tails, with sensory organs such as eyes, nostrils, and ears clustered on their heads. These help them find their way around and identify food. It is animals' ability to make decisions about where to go and why that makes them so different from plants and fungi.

Invertebrates

More than 95 percent of the animal species currently known to science are invertebrates—animals that do not have backbones and jointed internal skeletons. They include creatures such as insects, worms, snails, clams, crabs, jellyfish, and sea urchins.

Vertebrates

A very small proportion of all the animal species on Earth are vertebrates with internal skeletons. They are the fish, amphibians, reptiles, birds, and mammals. They include the largest animals, such as elephants, crocodiles, and whales.

▼ LITTLE AND LARGE

Animals take many forms. Here, a caiman—a type of crocodilian—provides a perch for tropical butterflies.

